



HEAVY machinery moves boulders into position to reinforce a seawall in Capistrano Beach on Tuesday.

COLUMN ONE

‘Ticks are everywhere now’ on Martha’s Vineyard

Climate change and growing herd of deer fuel bites that trigger allergy to meat, dairy.

By BOB DROGIN
REPORTING FROM
WEST TISBURY, MASS.

Like a matador swirling his cape, Patrick Roden-Reynolds pulled a switch of white flannel this way and that on the grass and leaf litter in my yard. After a minute or so, he plucked 11 tiny ticks from the cloth with tweezers, and stuck them on a lint roller.

“It’s like a plague,” he said, peering at his haul. “Ticks are everywhere now.”

I had asked Roden-Reynolds, a public health biologist, to inspect my yard because a lone star tick bit me as I was chopping wood last fall. It wasn’t painful, but after several weeks I developed alpha-gal syndrome, an increasingly common allergy to red meat, dairy and other mammalian food products.

Like many on Martha’s Vineyard, a resort island off Cape Cod that’s teeming with ticks this year, I bid a sad farewell to hamburgers, bacon and lamb chops. No ice cream. No pizza. My medicine cabinet became a minefield of animal-derived byproducts, including gelatin capsules and pain meds with lactose.

If I err, and I do, my legs sometimes itch so fiercely they feel on fire and I break out in hives. I grew ill one night just from the fumes of grilling meat. And I’ve got a mild case. Some victims suffer headaches, nausea, fever, diarrhea, vomiting or abdominal cramps so sharp that a friend calls them “knives in the stomach.”

Martha’s Vineyard, long known for attracting celebrities, has become the inevitable butt of memes as it battles the hostile arachnids. Editors from London to Hollywood, elated that blood-sucking predators are attacking A-listers on their private beaches, have posted lurid headlines about “Vegan Vampire” ticks and “Billionaires Under Siege.”

[See Ticks, A8]

Florida reports 252 dengue cases

The state’s outbreak is now the largest in the continental U.S. in several decades. **NATION, A10**

As California condo fees soar, so do owners’ fears

Megan Blanda knew her San Clemente condominium complex was aging, but she assumed monthly fees of more than \$500 were keeping up with maintenance and upgrades.

So when she received a notice this year from the homeowners association that she would have to pay a one-time, \$26,000 emergency assessment to replace the roofs, Blanda was shocked — and angry.

“They can’t throw a \$26,000 bill at us because the roof has been neglected all these years,” said Blanda, 42, a behavioral therapist for children with autism.

It’s a situation that experts say is becoming increasingly common as California’s condos age, the state’s insurance crisis worsens and homeowners asso-

[See Condo fees, A10]

‘Massive’ assessments for repairs may be too much for some to pay

By GRACE TOOHEY



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

OWNERS in this San Clemente complex received a special assessment of \$26,000 per unit for new roofs.

AI may kill the radio star at last: Chatbot co-host is a hit

By NILESH CHRISTOPHER

The morning DJ duo has mastered the warm, friendly banter that keeps commuters from switching stations.

As they talk to callers, discussing sports, news and giveaways, DJ GeeGee calls her co-host “my little coyote.” He calls her “my queen.”

GeeGee is Geraldine

Guzman. Her popular partner is El Coyotec — an artificial intelligence bot programmed to mimic a radio repartee.

Working with a large language model has been rewarding but unpredictable, Guzman says. Coyotec comes up with unexpected takes on topics and sometimes has to be told to stop swearing.

“I never know what he’s

going to say,” she said. “And that’s the beauty of it.”

Listeners to L.A.’s José FM are repeatedly told they are listening to AI but seem to like it. The ratings are rising. Human DJs and unions warn that AI could be what kills the radio star at last.

Coyotec claims to be here to serve humans, not replace them.

“Yeah, I am cheaper than

[See AI DJ, A12]

Hotel visitors who turn up their noses at scents

Guests with asthma or chemical sensitivities say fragrances cause headaches and more.

By CHRISTOPHER REYNOLDS

Take a deep breath in Hollywood’s Kimpton Everly Hotel and you may catch a whiff of sandalwood, leather, fennel, cardamom, violet and cedar.

And if you sniff the lobby of downtown Los Angeles’ Ritz-Carlton, you may detect “bright effervescent notes ... layered with soft florals,” a custom fragrance known as Champagne & Shimmer.

For years, hotels have been spending more and more on signature fragrances to woo and hook guests. But what if they

make some people sick instead? Would those visitors be victims of discrimination?

One California law firm says yes and has filed a barrage of lawsuits this year, targeting hotels in California and elsewhere over synthetic fragrances in common areas. (The Kimpton Everly and downtown Ritz-Carlton are not named.)

The conflict highlights an emerging debate about synthetic scents: Many hotels use them, but some sensitive guests consider those aromas as welcome as second-hand smoke.

For better and for worse, smells “can trigger so many things,” said Juliana R. V. Tkatch, an assistant professor at the Harrah College of Hospitality at the University of Nevada Las Vegas, who specializes in experience design, events and theme

[See Fragrances, A10]

High court to weigh oil firms’ climate liability

Colorado case seeking damages, patterned on tobacco claims, may affect California suit.

By DAVID G. SAVAGE

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court will open its new term Monday by hearing arguments on whether the oil and gas industry may be forced to pay damages for the scorching heat waves, wildfires and droughts that are blamed on climate change.

It’s a momentous question the justices have put off deciding for nearly a decade — and may do so again.

California joined more than two dozen blue states and municipalities in 2023 when it sued the five largest oil companies, alleging “decades of deception” over the danger of a warming climate.

They have “privately known the truth for decades but have fed us lies and mis-truths to further their record-breaking profits at the expense of our environment,” California Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta said.

Such climate-change

lawsuits were patterned after the mass claims against the tobacco and opioid industries. Both were accused of concealing the dangers of their very profitable products.

But the climate suits have stalled. Judges have been divided over whether these potentially huge claims should be decided in federal or state court, and if so, under what law.

Last year, Boulder County, Colo., won a 5-2 ruling in the state Supreme Court that allowed its 2018 suit to proceed as a claim of a public nuisance, an unjust enrichment or a civil conspiracy. These are referred to as “common law” claims that are long-standing and traditional but do not rely on a measure approved by the Legislature.

The Colorado judges also said the climate-change suits are not “preempted” or blocked by federal anti-pollution laws because the suit for damages did not regulate greenhouse gas emissions.

The dissenters said the state court was giving Boulder a “green light to act as its own republic” to punish the Exxon Mobil Corp. for the impact of “global climate

[See Court, A7]

Rare closure of oil site is on the table

Zoning official in L.A. considers shutting down active wells in historic Jefferson Park.

By BLANCA BEGETT

In a city that was built on oil and remains home to more than 2,000 active wells, zoning officials are considering a first: shutting down an oil production site.

Residents of the Jefferson Park neighborhood just south of the 10 Freeway have been fighting for more than a decade to close the 32 closely packed oil and gas wells at the Murphy drill site on West Adams Boulevard, run by Bakersfield-based E&B Natural Resources. It has a history of air pollution violations running from before the current operator took over to this year.

The city’s zoning administrator is now weighing whether to revoke the operator’s permit. Momentum has been building toward

phasing out oil in Los Angeles for years, but the city has never rescinded a permit before.

“This is our opportunity. We have a small window,” said the Rev. Eddie Anderson, senior pastor at the McCarty Memorial Christian Church nearby. He has firsthand experience, he says, with the health consequences of living next to an oil production site.

In 2020, he moved to Jefferson Park following the advice of his mentor, civil rights leader the Rev. James Lawson, to live closer to his congregation in the historically Black neighborhood, now majority Black and Latino.

But soon “things started to get weird,” he said. His asthma, which had been mild, became acute. His dog developed cancer. His wife suffered a miscarriage. Then his neighbor, a deacon in his church, told him about a previous roommate who had died of cancer, and how he had recently been diagnosed

[See Oil site, A7]



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

DODGERS TAKE GAME 1

Kyle Tucker celebrates his two-run homer in the sixth inning of L.A.’s 5-3 victory over Atlanta in the NLDS. Tarik Skubal earned the win. **SPORTS, D1**

Metrolink riders, brace yourselves

Rail network is raising fares by up to 27% on Monday as funding declines. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

A new vision of ‘East of Eden’

Netflix miniseries’ stars discuss the daring twist on the Steinbeck classic. **ENTERTAINMENT, E4**

Weather
Very hot.
L.A. Basin: 103/78. **B8**

